

Original Mav dies

Journeyman forward battled demons but left mark on Dallas in '80s

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Abdul Jeelani, who scored the first points in Mavericks history, died Wednesday after suffering a heart attack. He was 62.



Abdul Jeelani, who scored the first points in Mavericks history, died Wednesday night in his hometown of Racine, Wis., hours after suffering a heart attack.

Jeelani, 62, played only one of his two NBA seasons as a Maverick, but he left an indelible mark in Dallas. Most enduring was what occurred on Oct. 11, 1980, in the early moments of a 103-92 victory over San Antonio at Reunion Arena.

Jeelani's 17-foot jumper from the left corner accounted for the first two of the 290,512 regular-season points the Mavericks franchise has scored to date.

"Absolutely one of the highlights of my career," Jeelani told The News in 2011. "For a journeyman like myself, that's like the Hall of Fame, to be forever linked to a franchise in such a manner."

That spring, The News chronicled Jeelani's roller coaster career and life, which included stardom at Wisconsin-Parkside and, after NBA stints with Portland and Dallas, a successful overseas playing career until 1989.

Post-basketball, however, Jeelani spiraled through cocaine, heroin and alcohol addiction, diabetes, prostate cancer and panic attacks. On the 30th anniversary of that first Mavericks basket, he was living in a Racine homeless shelter.

When The News sat down with him six months later, however, Jeelani had moved in with daughter Kareema and three of his seven grandchildren.

And he was about to embark on an opportunity to do publicservice work in Italy for Project Colors, a nonprofit that aids low-income or orphaned children from 27 countries.

Jeelani had been a beloved player in Italy. When fans and media there learned of his homelessness, they raised funds for him to return to a hero's welcome.

"You find out that in life, you never know what impact you have on others until a situation like this, when you're in a homeless shelter," Jeelani told The News in 2011.

“The power of the human spirit is incredible. Humans are pretty awesome when we want to be and the need arises.

“Life is beautiful again. I’m rebuilding mine.”

On Thursday, Project Colors tweeted to The News: “We will always remember him with the kids of Project Colors he played with when he came back to Rome in 2011!”

In 2013, Jeelani was inducted into the Racine County Sports Hall of Fame.

Mavericks fans who are old enough to remember the 6-8 small forward also probably recall his amazing run of fourthquarter heroics during that inaugural season.

After not playing in the first three quarters of a Dec. 26 home game against Denver, Jeelani exploded for 20 final-quarter points in a comeback win.

On Jan. 13, he scored 16 fourth-quarter points in a home victory over Chicago. Three nights later, he personally outscored the Knicks 21-20 in the fourth quarter of another home win.

Jeelani was one of 21 players who suited up at various times for the Mavericks that first season and was one of only four players to begin and end the season in Dallas.

“The first thing you think of when you say ‘Abdul Jeelani’ are his fourth quarters,” said Mavericks assistant general manager Keith Grant, who was the team’s equipment manager in 1980-81. “He was basketball’s version of the closer — on a team that only won 15 games, for godsakes.”

And for all eternity, Jeelani is the answer to perhaps the ultimate Mavericks trivia question.